



PARCHED THROATS: Villagers fishing for water in a dug well in Gujarat in 2003

Indian government identified the Sholapur hand pump as the device that made drawing water from deeper sources easy. It was reinvented and called India Mark II. Unlike its cast-iron predecessor, this device was made of steel, with standardised specifications. "In a country where about 70 per cent of the land surface is hard rock, this was a technological revolution which ensured safe drinking water," says S.C. Jain, programme coordinator at the non-profit organisation—Action for Food Production. UNICEF figures indicate there were 36 manufacturers producing 1,00,000 pumps every year in 1984, which rose to 2,00,000 by 1987. The pump was also exported to countries in Africa and Latin America and was even upgraded to India Mark III.

It became the answer to a decentralised water system. But now, two decades later, environmentalists are rethinking the device, considered the panacea to all water-related problems. Because this technology, says The Ecological Foundation's Sudhirendra

Rs 14,550 61 m

is the amount of money needed to install one India Mark II hand pump

families draw water from hand pumps or community taps, according to a survey in 2000

Sharma, merged land rights and water rights. Environmentalists also say that governments often neglected proper training for villagers for the maintenance and upkeep of the pumps.

Like at Rangpuri Pahari Nala where there are 22 hand pumps, many of which have stopped working. Some, resident Dwarka Prasad says, need repair and maintenance, while some others have seen a dip in the water level. He points to a hand pump surrounded by women holding containers, waiting for their turn. "The water used to be 30 feet deep," he says. "Then the water stopped. We collected money from the villagers and dug further to about 70 feet before we could access the water." Now, they want pipelines with a 24-hour supply, just like the village next door.

The India Mark II was a technology that was perhaps the most democratic in principle. It was a simple tool that brought water to a parched nation and made it an accessible commodity. ■

D.K. BISWAS, Central Pollution Control Board chairman, 1997

"It's difficult to get water of any kind, let alone clean water. And the problem can only worsen."